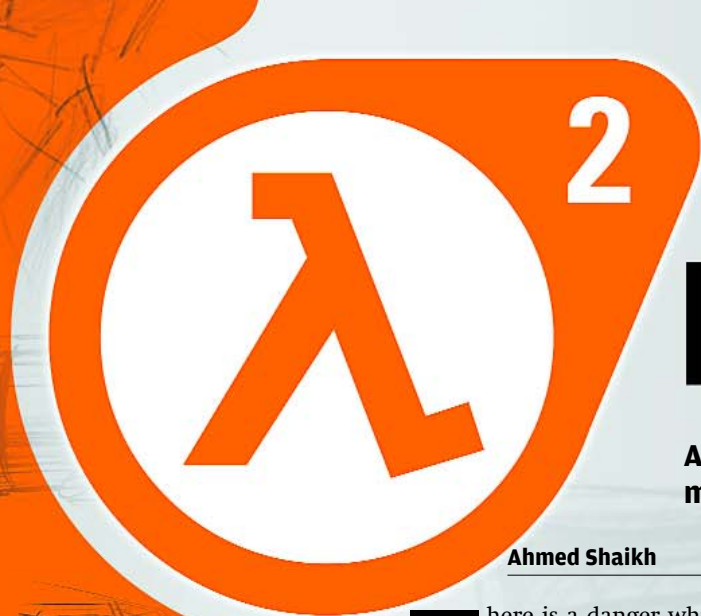




HALFLIFE²

A visual tour of the best gaming experience your money can buy. Serious!

Ahmed Shaikh

There is a danger while reviewing a product with a heritage that *Half-Life 2* enjoys. When you have waited for a game for close to two years, built a computer system for its imminent arrival, have hungrily consumed every nugget of information thrown by the Almighty Valve, there is a tendency that you will end up praising it, even if it—technically speaking—sucks. Wait, before you rip out clumps of hair—the game rocks... honest!

What makes *Half-Life 2* the most amazing virtual experience yet is the beauty of the world it creates. The

game system makes inherent sense. It is visually stunning, starring believable characters that showcase emotive expressions; it is supported by a laudable simulation of real-world physics, and is paced to perfection.

Within 15 minutes of playing it, you will go through curiosity, elation, surprise, fear, revulsion, dread, relief, and joy.

The emotive package is ably wrapped in a musical score which thrills, chills and rides your adrenaline back down to human levels. I do not exaggerate when I say that every moment of playing the game is a surprise, it feels fresh and invigorating

right up to the somewhat-deflated end (blame it on bloody sequels!)

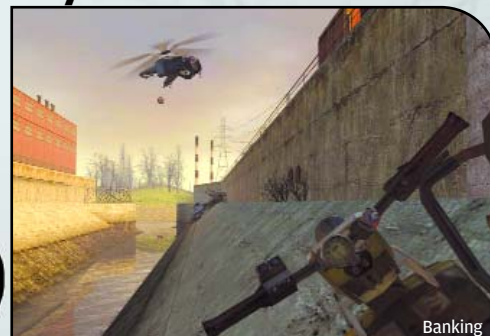
Having poured praise, my ego must point out some flaws—the installation takes an eternity (thanks to the Steam decryption and verification systems); like the first, the game is too scripted, and loading times will frequently throw a wrench at, what is otherwise, a study in immersion. That aside, the game is perfection itself.

Do yourself a favour and play it at all costs.

ahmed_shaikh@thinkdigit.com



Physics



Banking



A lever system

Half-Life 2 tests your physics IQ. During the game, you will need to surmount various challenges based on the principles of physics, such as a pulley-based puzzle shown below. The game employs the Havoc physics engine, as a result of which, the simulations by HL2 are believable and immersive. For a more satisfying usage of real-world logic, read on...



A pulley system



Buoyancy